code you need to write. And you'll see how these executable specifications can be a powerful reporting and living-documentation tool.

2.4.1 Going from examples to acceptance criteria

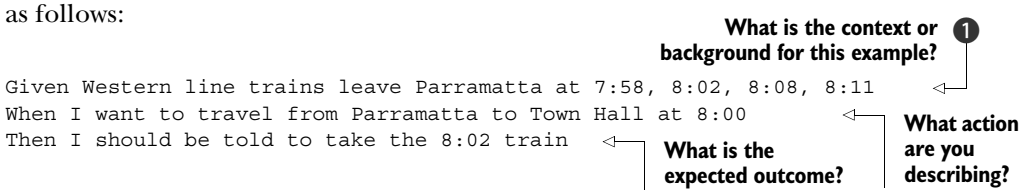
You can use your examples (such as Jill's commuter trip examples) as the basis for the acceptance criteria. In a nutshell, the acceptance criteria are what will satisfy stakeholders (and QA) that the application does what it's supposed to do.

Conversations like the one with Jill (in section 2.3.3) are a great way to build up your understanding of the problem space, but you can take things a lot further if you use a slightly more structured style. In BDD, the following notation is often used to express examples:[4]

```
Given <a context>
When <something happens>
Then <you expect some outcome>
```

This format helps you think in terms of how users interact with the system and what the outcomes should be. As you'll see in the next section, they're also easy to convert into automated acceptance tests using tools like Cucumber and JBehave. But because you may want to automate these tests later on, their format is a little less flexible. As you'll see, words like *Given*, *When*, and *Then* have special meanings for these tools, so it's best to think of them as special keywords.

Using this notation, you could express the requirement mentioned previously as follows:



When you talk through this example with Jill, she points out that trains travel in two directions on a line, so the *Given* section 1 is incomplete—you also need to give a starting point and a direction. Or, if you give the destination station, you can work out the direction of the trains from this. You could refine this scenario as follows:

```
Given Western line trains from Emu Plains leave Parramatta
for Town Hall at 7:58, 8:00, 8:02, 8:11
When I want to travel from Parramatta to Town Hall at 8:00
Then I should be told to take the 8:02 train
```

Includes both the line name and the direction

When you talk this example through, though, you realize that you only have two minutes to buy a ticket and get to the right platform. You really need to be told about the next few trains:

---

[4] The syntax shown here is sometimes referred to as the Gherkin format, but this is not strictly accurate—Gherkin is the syntax used by Cucumber and related tools, whereas these examples use JBehave. We'll look at all this in great detail in chapter 5.